

Malik. Clearly, even punishment such as being stripped of rank has failed to deter corruption at the top.

The findings of the COI which went into the Sukhna land deal are yet to become fully known but it is clear that the army will study its implications for long. What, for instance, will be the impact on the office of the military secretary (MS), one of the eight principal staff officers who report to the army chief and are handpicked by him. The MS not only heads all the promotion boards of the army but handles the postings of all officers above the rank of colonel and also hands out the gallantry awards and foreign postings of officers.

"It will take the army years to erase the perceived taint on the office of the military secretary," says Colonel RSN Singh (retired).

Army analysts warn it will lead to an increasingly cautious army. Senior officers will become wary of dealing with anything that deals with land or with large procurements. It will lead to a nervous chain of command that will think twice before implementing orders received from their superiors. These spell serious repercussions for an army that demands unquestioned compliance of orders. "The public image of general officers will take a beating and you are looking at a status-quoist army," says Major General Surjit Singh (retired).

The genesis of the contentious 70-acre plot has its origins in the dwindling fortunes of the Darjeeling tea industry in the late 1990s. In 2005, a developer Dilip Kumar Aggarwal stepped in and took it up as a tea tourism project called

Oxford. It was part of the West Bengal Government's plan to revive the tea industry. The project would turn part of the estate into a tourism project with house parks and villas for tourists. In 2006, Bengali film actor Pransanjit performed the *shilanyas* for the project. This is when alarm bells went off at the headquarters of the army's 33 Corps at Sukhna which defends Siliguri's vital 'chicken neck' which joins the North-east with the rest of the country. Fearing an influx of foreign tourists, the then GOC denied permis-

headquarters, Sukhna, and four of the lessees of the 70-acre plot.

The grant of the noc to the project immediately raised suspicion within Fort William, the headquarters of the army's Eastern Command. This was partly because the command had earlier objected to the MOU and had even proposed acquiring the land. In October, nearly six months after the MOU had been signed, Lt-General Singh ordered the inquiry.

"The land doesn't belong to the army and there was no transfer of land

nor was money involved. Where is the scam?" asks Aggarwal. He says he went to get an noc from the army only to avoid trouble in future and protect his investment. Investigating officials admit the COI which probed lapses in procedure would barely stand scrutiny in a civil court but in the army such a deviation from procedure is seen as crossing the line.

"The two generals, Rath and Prakash, did commit gross impropriety. We have enough evidence within the purview of the Army Act to proceed against

them," says an official involved in the investigations. According to evidence presented before the COI, Lt-General Prakash is alleged to have influenced Lt-General Rath's decision to grant the noc to the institution. Lt-General Prakash is close to Aggarwal (a fact admitted to by the latter). Clearly with pressure mounting on the chief to act on the recommendations of his army commander, another installment in the painful saga of army corruption is set to begin. ■

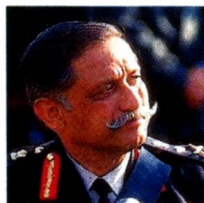


“ Such cases must be dealt with promptly and exemplary punishment given, which the army seems to be doing. ”

GENERAL V.P. MALIK, *former Chief of Army Staff*

“ The image of officers will take a beating. It will lead to cautious officers and a status-quoist army. ”

MAJOR-GENERAL SURJIT SINGH (RETD.)



“ There is anger over this but the army is unique among all institutions in the country as it is taking harsh action. ”

GENERAL S. ROYCHOWDHURY (RETD.)

sion to the project. In December last year, the 33 Corps headquarters even proposed acquiring the land for security reasons. Meanwhile, finding the resort project shelved, the developer decided to convert it into a residential educational institution.

In February this year, the 33 Corps headquarters reversed its earlier decision to give a verbal 'no objection' to the utilisation of the land for the residential school. An MOU was signed between the station commander, station